

D.C.'s Office of Women's Policy and Initiatives Navigates The Aftermath of the Big, Beautiful Bill

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Mayor Muriel Bowser's proposed budget for FY2027 details no money has been allocated to the Mayor's Office of Women's Policy Initiatives (MOWPI). This creates a troubling trend, as the FY2026 budget also included no funds, and FY2025 noted a decrease in budget for the agency.

The stated priority for the FY2027 budget is increasing revenue for the city and scaling back on what the administration has characterized as unnecessary programs. These programs include the TANF employment program, universal paid leave, substance use disorder community support, rapid rehousing, and the child care educator subsidy. According to Mayor Bowser, these programs are not yielding desired results or in some cases, any results at all. Congresswoman Rosa DeLauro (CT-03), a prominent advocate for women's rights in the House of Representatives, has closely watched the effects of these cuts accumulate over time.



Mayor Bowser at the unveiling of the FY2027 budget

"You get sick, your kids get sick, there's nobody at home, you take your time off, and you don't get paid," DeLauro said in response to the Universal Paid Leave program being eliminated, saving the city \$95 million in FY2027. "Childcare, daycare, these are issues that affect women," she added, speaking to the defunding of the child care educator subsidy.

MOWPI's stated mission is to enhance the quality of life for all women and their families within the District of Columbia, serving as a liaison between the public and private sectors and the Executive Office of the Mayor. The office also works to increase the number of supportive housing units for expectant mothers and to decrease the waiting period for acceptance into those programs. Without a dedicated budget, however, MOWPI's ability to fulfill that mission becomes even more difficult. Staff capacity, outreach efforts, and partnership development all depend on sustained institutional funding, none of which is guaranteed under the current proposal.

After the One Big Beautiful Bill Act (OBBBA) was passed in July 2025, there has been a notable and accelerating decrease in funding for public programs and resources at the federal level. Most significantly, the legislation included a \$1 trillion cut in Medicaid and other health programs projected over the next decade. In the District of Columbia, this disproportionately affects women, who make up 52% of Medicaid recipients. Many of the specific health programs facing defunding, such as reproductive healthcare, maternal health services, and mental health support, are targeted directly, compounding the harm already caused by local budget reductions.

The intersection of federal and local cuts places D.C. women in a particularly precarious position. Where federal policy cuts a lifeline, local government would traditionally step in as a backstop. But with MOWPI effectively defunded and the city pulling back from social programs simultaneously, that safety net is thinning from both ends.

The most direct response MOWPI has had to these budget cuts was hosting an informational session on December 10, 2025, specifically for women enrolled in Medicaid who were anxious about losing coverage in D.C. The session offered guidance on navigating changes, understanding eligibility, and connecting with

remaining resources — a crucial but reactive measure in the face of sweeping policy change.

MOWPI has also been working to maintain its full slate of community programs, including its annual Women's History Month programming, WorkSmart/SmartStart salary negotiation workshops, and the Washington Women of Excellence Awards. These initiatives are designed to connect with the community on a personal level, building relationships and providing tangible skills in the absence of larger structural supports. But they too are now threatened by the ripple effects of the OBBBA and the mounting pressure on city agencies to justify their budgets.

What remains to be seen is whether advocacy efforts from organizations like MOWPI, from congressional voices like DeLauro's, and from community members themselves can make a change before the FY2027 budget is finalized. For the women of Washington, D.C., the answer to that question is not abstract. It will determine whether they have paid leave when a child falls ill, whether they can afford childcare, whether they have housing when pregnant and without stable income, and whether anyone in government is still charged with making sure those needs are counted.

“It is still harder for women in this institution,” concluded DeLauro, “because women now have to work harder. We have to stand up and we have to know what we’re talking about.”

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